

*Bubo virginianus*

Great horned owl

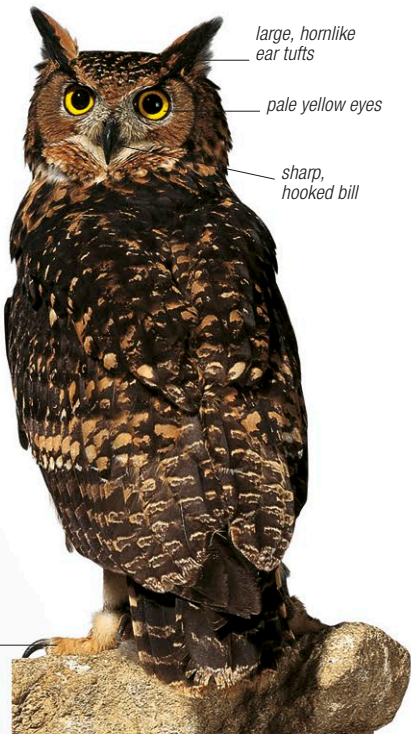


**Length** 20–23½ in (50–60 cm)  
**Weight** 1½–5½ lb (675–2,500 g)  
**Plumage** Sexes similar  
**Migration** Nonmigrant  
**Status** Least concern

**Location** North, Central, and South America



The great horned owl, with its distinctive ear tufts, or “horns,” is the largest of the American owls and is found throughout the Americas. It occurs in a broad range of habitats, from forest to desert, and is known to nest at high altitudes, usually in old nests of other large birds, but also in tree cavities and on cliff edges. It is generally a sedentary bird and, especially during the breeding season, very territorial in its nesting and hunting ranges. Usually active between dusk and dawn, its night vision and hearing are extremely acute, making it an effective hunter. Its main prey are small mammals, but insects, reptiles, amphibians, and birds, including other owl species, are also taken. Great horned owls are very vocal, especially during courtship; their loud hoot represents the classic owl call.



POWERFUL BUILD

*This very large owl, with its sharp bill, large wings, and powerful talons, is built for hunting. Its piercing yellow eyes and prominent ear tufts add to its intimidating appearance.*



SILENT HUNTER

*As well as being the largest American owl, the great horned owl is probably also the fiercest. It mainly still-hunts from a series of favored vantage points throughout its territory. It is very swift, and having spotted a target, it glides down, in total silence, to capture its prey in its immensely powerful talons.*

PARENTS AND JUVENILES



ON THE NEST

*The great horned owl lays between one and 5 eggs, laying a greater number when food is abundant.*

Great horned owls are very attentive parents, with both males and females tending and feeding their young for at least 6 weeks after fledging. They are also very defensive birds and have been known to drive away intruding humans from their nests.



JUVENILE OWL

*At about 2 months old, the horned owl is almost fully feathered and capable of short flights. At this stage, it can puff itself up and turn its wings forward to look even larger when defending itself.*